



HARVESTING

When plants reach approximately 2 in (5 cm) in height, harvest the outer leaves a few at a time for use in salads. When plants are about 10–12 weeks old, either cut a few leaves as and when you need them, or harvest the whole plant; either uproot completely, or cut the tops off leaving about 1 in (2.5 cm) above the ground. This stump may resprout and provide you with a second crop.

STORING

Spinach does not keep well after harvesting, so sow successionally for a year-round crop instead.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Because spinach grows quickly, it is usually a relatively trouble-free crop, but you may need to use netting to deter birds. Slugs and snails may target crops, and diseases such as downy mildew may be a problem. This causes white mold on the underside of leaves, with yellowish-brown patches on the top. Remove and destroy the affected leaves to prevent the spread of infection, and spray the remaining crops with a fungicide. Giving plants plenty of space will help to reduce the risk. Resistant cultivars are available.